

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Teaching Notes, Part 6: Unit V, The Methods of Theology (Lectures 23 to 29)

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These are your notes. Each lecture gives the opening problem, the teaching content, the references, the cross-references to the rest of the course, the illustrations for the board, and a teaching tip with the reading and the reflection prompt.

THE ARC OF UNIT V

Unit V is the heart of the whole course. It answers the third goal carried to its depth, how theology is actually done, and it bears the third precept of Bernard Lonergan, be reasonable. Having attended to the sources in Unit III, and having understood the history in Unit IV, the student now reaches the question on which his whole working life will turn: by what method does a theologian move from Scripture, Tradition, the experience of the faithful, and the cry of his own people, to a faithful and living word for today? Everything before this unit was preparation; everything after it is application. If the students grasp nothing else in the course, let them grasp this unit, for it hands them the tools of the trade.

The unit moves in seven steps. Lecture 23 lays down the general shape of method, the four pillars on which all theology rests, the pastoral cycle of seeing, judging, and acting, and the circle, or rather the spiral, by which the theologian reads the text and the world together. Lecture 24 shows why theology needs many methods and not one, and gives the students the idea of a model, taken from Stephen Bevans. Lecture 25 sets out the six models in one view: translation, anthropological, praxis, synthetic, transcendental, and countercultural. Then four lectures put the models to work in the living theologies the students will actually meet and serve. Lecture 26 takes up the praxis model in liberation and Dalit theology, the view from below. Lecture 27 takes up the anthropological and synthetic models in Indian theology, inculturation and the conversation with the *darshanas*. Lecture 28 takes up the praxis and countercultural models in theology done in the voice of a woman. And Lecture 29 closes the unit with the theology of the Christian East, theology on its knees.

The thread through all seven is reasonableness in the exact sense Lonergan gave it: having attended to the data and grasped the insight, now weigh, marshal the reasons, judge, and choose well. To be reasonable in method is to pick the tool the question and the context call for, to give reasons for the choice, and to test every theology by two measures, whether it holds together and whether it is faithful, that is, whether it coheres and whether it keeps the marks of authentic theology from Lecture 10. The sin against this unit runs two ways. There is the man with no method at all, who does theology by mood and by the last book he happened to read; and there is the partisan, who seizes one method as a weapon and will not weigh any other. Both have failed to be reasonable. Keep the precept be reasonable on

the board for these seven days, beside the question of each lecture, and ask at the close of each class which model was at work and why it fitted the matter at hand.

LECTURE 23: How does a theologian actually work?

The opening problem. The students have learned what theology is, why it is done, where it draws its content, and how it grew through history. Now comes the plain and slightly frightening question of the practitioner: when a theologian sits down to write a homily, an article, a pastoral letter, or a thesis, what does he actually do? Is there a craft here that can be learned, a disciplined way of working, or does each person simply set down his opinions and dress them in pious words? Pose it bluntly, because many students secretly fear that theology is only educated opinion. The answer is that theology is a craft with a real method, and the heart of that method is this: theology is faith reflecting on the whole of life, drawing on four steady sources, moving through a disciplined cycle, and returning again and again, like a spiral climbing a tower, to read the Word of God and the world of human beings each in the light of the other.

The teaching content. The four pillars. Begin by gathering what the students already have. The materials the theologian works with are the four pillars named in the architecture of this course and again in Lecture 15: Sacred Scripture, the living Tradition, the faith experience of the believer and the believing community, and the social context, the signs of the times. A theology that stands on only one pillar leans and falls. A homily that is all Scripture and no context floats above the heads of the people; a reflection that is all context and no Scripture is social commentary with a hymn at the end; a thesis that is all Tradition and no experience is a museum piece. Method is, first of all, the discipline of standing on all four pillars at once, letting the Word, the Tradition, the experience of the faithful, and the real situation of the people speak to one another in the one piece of work.

The pastoral cycle: see, judge, act. Then give them the movement that turns these four pillars into a way of working, the pastoral cycle, which began with Joseph Cardijn and the young workers, was taken up by John XXIII in *Mater et Magistra*, and became the working method of the Church in Latin America and Asia. See: begin by looking, hard and honestly, at the real situation, the actual lives, sufferings, and hopes of the people, with the help of the human sciences, so that you do not theologise about a village that exists only in your imagination. Judge: bring that seen reality to the light of the Word of God and the Tradition, and ask what God is saying in and to this situation, what here is of the Kingdom and what is against it. Act: let the reflection issue in a concrete response, a changed practice, a word that can actually be lived, and not merely a conclusion to be filed away. This is not three tidy boxes but a living movement, and it answers the old complaint that theology is useless: rightly done, theology begins in real life and returns to it changed.

The hermeneutic circle. Now add the deeper insight that keeps the cycle honest, the hermeneutic circle, which the students meet in the reading from Segundo. No one comes to the Scripture with an empty head. Every reader brings a pre-understanding, shaped by his culture, his class, his interests, and his blind spots, and that pre-understanding silently

steers what he sees in the text and what he fails to see. The hermeneutic circle is the discipline of becoming aware of this. Juan Luis Segundo set it out in four movements, which you can give the students simply: a new and disturbing experience of reality makes us suspect that our usual ideas, even our usual theology, may be serving interests we had not noticed; we turn that suspicion on the whole structure of our ideas, and on our theology; we then suspect that the common reading of Scripture itself has quietly left out important truth; and so we return to the Scripture with new eyes and read it afresh, and the fresh reading sends us back to change our lives, where a newer experience begins the circle again. The point for the student is humbling and freeing at once: there is no innocent reading, and the honest theologian keeps testing his own lenses, so that the Word may correct him and not merely echo him.

Holding it together, and the payoff. Tell the students that these three, the four pillars, the pastoral cycle, and the hermeneutic circle, are not three rival methods but one craft seen from three sides. The four pillars name the materials; the pastoral cycle names the movement; the hermeneutic circle names the honesty. And here the precept of the unit shows itself: to work this way is to be reasonable, to give reasons, to test, to let the evidence and the Word judge the worker, rather than to pour out unexamined opinion. The payoff for a priest in Bengal is immediate. The homily he preaches next Sunday will be true theology if he has looked honestly at the lives of his people, brought those lives to the Word and the Tradition, returned with a word that can be lived, and checked his own blind spots along the way. Method is not a cage for the Spirit; it is the discipline that keeps the Spirit-filled word from collapsing into the mere mood of the preacher.

Illustration. The first image is the weaver at the loom. Watch a weaver in a Bengal village set up the loom. First she stretches the warp, the long, strong threads fixed tight on the frame, running the whole length of the cloth and never moving; these are Scripture and Tradition, the fixed and load-bearing threads, the same from end to end. Then she takes the shuttle and runs the weft across, back and forth, thread after thread of the day, the colour of this season, the pattern this customer asked for; this is the faith experience and the social context, woven freshly across the fixed warp. The cloth is one only because the moving weft is woven through the steady warp; warp with no weft is a bare frame, and weft with no warp is a heap of loose thread. Method is the disciplined weaving that makes the four pillars into one cloth, and a theology that drops the warp, or refuses the weft, never becomes cloth at all.

The second image is the spiral staircase. A man who climbs a spiral staircase inside a tower passes the same side of the tower again and again, the same window, the same wall; a careless watcher might think he is going in circles and getting nowhere. But he is not back where he began; each time he comes round he is higher, and from the same window he now sees further, the courtyard, then the rooftops, then the river, then the far fields. The hermeneutic circle is such a spiral. The theologian returns to the same Scripture and the same human life over and over, and it can look like going round in circles; but each return is from higher up, with more seen, more understood, more honestly. A theology that only ever stands on the ground floor, reading the text once and never returning, never sees the river;

and a man who imagines he has reached the top and need not climb again has stopped being a theologian.

References. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, Chapter 4, pages 42 to 57, for the structure and method of contemporary theology. Juan Luis Segundo, *The Liberation of Theology* (1976), for the four movements of the hermeneutic circle. Joseph Cardijn, for the see, judge, and act of the pastoral cycle, and John XXIII, *Mater et Magistra* (1961), section 236, for its adoption in the teaching of the Church. Gaudium et Spes 4 and 11, for the reading of the signs of the times. For the four pillars, the architecture of this course and Lecture 15.

Cross-references. The four pillars come from the architecture of the course and from Lecture 15, where reason, experience, and the cry of the poor were added to Scripture, Tradition, and the teaching office. The hermeneutic circle reaches back to the turn to the subject in Lecture 8 and forward into every model that follows, and above all into the praxis model of Lecture 26. Seeing, judging, and acting return in liberation and Dalit theology in Lecture 26, in Indian theology in Lecture 27, and in the responsible theologian of Lecture 34. The honesty about our own lenses prepares the whole of Unit V, for each model is a different lens, and being reasonable means knowing which lens you are using and why.

For the professor. Make this lecture intensely practical, for it is where the students stop being spectators of theology and start being practitioners. Take one real situation from a Bengal parish, a family losing its land, a girl pulled out of school, a flood, and walk the whole class through the pastoral cycle on it, see, judge, act, on the board, so that they feel the method in their hands and not only in their notes. Warn them gently about the hermeneutic circle, that the Bible can be made to echo our own comfort if we never suspect our own reading. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 4, pages 42 to 57; Segundo on the hermeneutic circle. Reflection prompt: "One blind spot in the way I usually read the Bible, which I have begun to notice, is..."

LECTURE 24: Why does theology need many models?

The opening problem. The students have just learned that theology has a method. Now they meet a surprise that can unsettle them: theology has not one method but many, and good and faithful theologians work in genuinely different ways. The student who likes things tidy will ask, with some anxiety, surely there must be one correct method, and the rest are mistakes? And if there are many, is it not all just personal taste again, with each theologian doing as he pleases? Pose the worry honestly, for it is the same worry about plurality that the students met in Lecture 11, now returning at the level of method. The answer is the idea of a model, and it is one of the most useful tools this whole course will give them. A model is not a finished theory and not a personal whim; it is a way of working, fitted to a context and a question, partial but true, and the reasonable theologian learns to recognise the models, to choose the one the matter calls for, and often to combine them.

The teaching content. What a model is. Take the idea of a model carefully, because the students will use it for the rest of the unit. A model is a partial and illuminating way of representing something too large to be captured all at once. It is true, but it is not the whole truth; it shows some features clearly by leaving others in shadow; and because of this, several models can be needed together, each showing what the others miss. Avery Dulles taught the Church to think this way about the Church herself and about revelation, and Stephen Bevans, whom the students will follow through this unit, applied it to the doing of theology in context. A model in theology is a coherent way of bringing the Gospel and a human situation together, with its own starting point, its own stresses, its own strengths, and its own dangers. To call something a model is already to be reasonable about it: it is to admit that it sees truly and partially, and that it must be weighed against the others and against the marks of Lecture 10.

Why many models, and not one. Now give the reason there must be more than one, and root it in things the students already hold. The mystery of God is infinite, and the human mind is finite, which is the one and the many of Lecture 11; the contexts in which the Gospel must take flesh are many, the Santali village and the city campus and the migrant worksite are not the same; and the questions people bring are many, for the man crushed by injustice, the woman silenced in the Church, the seeker drawn to the silence of God, and the believer facing the doubter all ask different things. One single method, forced onto every context and every question, will serve some well and do violence to the rest. So the variety of models is not a failure of theology to make up its mind; it is the honest response of one Gospel to many peoples and many questions. The danger is not having many models; the danger is the man who knows only one and uses it on everything, like a workman with only a hammer, who treats every problem as a nail.

The two tests, and the limits of models. Guard the students at once against turning this into the relativism they feared. To say there are many models is not to say that anything goes, any more than the many theologies of Lecture 11 meant that all of them were true. Every model must pass the two tests of the reasonable theologian. The first is coherence: does it hold together, or does it contradict itself? The second is fidelity: does it keep the marks of authentic theology from Lecture 10, is it biblical, traditional, ecclesial, oriented to worship and to the love of the poor, and does it stay within the banks beyond which lies not plurality but heresy? A model that fails these tests is not a fresh method but a corruption. So the freedom of many models is a freedom under the Word and within the Church, the very balance the students learned about Scripture in Lecture 12 and about plurality in Lecture 11.

The payoff. Tell the students plainly what this gives them. It frees them from two fears at once: the fear that their teacher and their bishop and the liberation theologian and the Orthodox monk must all be doing the same thing in the same way, and the fear that, since they are not, it must all be opinion. It hands them instead a calm and reasonable habit: when they read any theology, or write any, they can ask, which model is at work here, what does it see well, what does it leave in shadow, and is it the right tool for this question and this people? That single habit will make them, for the rest of their lives, careful readers and honest writers rather than partisans of one school.

Illustration. The first image is the carpenter and his bag of tools. A carpenter who comes to mend your house does not pull out one tool and use it for everything. He has a saw for cutting, a plane for smoothing, a chisel for the joint, a drill for the hole, a hammer for the nail, and the mark of the skilled man is not that he loves one tool above the rest but that he knows, at a glance, which tool the work in front of him needs. A boy with only a hammer will ruin the door he was asked to plane. The models of theology are the tools in the bag; the skilled theologian is the one who reads the job, the context and the question, and reaches for the model that fits, and who knows that a fine tool used on the wrong task does harm. To be reasonable in theology is, in good part, to know your tools and to choose well among them.

The second image is the fisherman and his nets on the Hooghly. A fisherman on the river does not own a single net and use it for every water. He keeps a fine close net for the small fish near the bank, a wide drift net for the deep channel, and a cast net to throw by hand in the shallows, and before he chooses, he reads the water, its depth, its current, the time of day, the fish that run in this season. The wrong net in the wrong water comes up empty or comes up torn. The models are the nets, the human situation is the water, and a faithful word is the catch; and the first work of the theologian, before he chooses any net, is to read the water honestly, which is the seeing of Lecture 23. A man who throws the same net into every river all his life will feed no one and will blame the fish.

References. The Manual, pages 4 to 5, for the notion of theological method and the *loci* of theology. Gerhard Ludwig Müller, *Katholische Dogmatik*, as cited in the Manual, for method and the sources of dogmatic theology. Stephen B. Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology*, revised edition (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2002), the opening chapters, for the idea of a model and the case for many models. Avery Dulles, *Models of the Church* and *Models of Revelation*, for the use of models in theology. For the two tests, coherence and fidelity, the marks of authentic theology from Lecture 10.

Cross-references. The idea that one truth is rightly spoken in many ways comes from the one and the many of Lecture 11, and the two tests of coherence and fidelity come from the marks and the banks of Lecture 10. The honesty about each model seeing partially reaches back to the hermeneutic circle of Lecture 23. The six models named here are set out in Lecture 25 and then put to work in Lectures 26 to 29. The freedom under the Word echoes the account of Scripture in Lecture 12. The precept be reasonable is the whole point of the lecture: to weigh the models and choose, rather than to grab one or to despair of all.

For the professor. The students most likely to stumble here are the tidy-minded ones who want a single right answer, and the cynical ones who hear many methods and conclude it is all opinion. Speak to both. To the first, show that many tools is not confusion but competence; to the second, show that the two tests, coherence and fidelity, keep the many models honest and rule out the corruptions. Do not yet teach the six models in detail; that is the next lecture. Here, fix only the idea of a model and the habit of asking, of any theology, which model is at work and is it the right one. Reading: the Manual, pages 4 to 5, with Müller. Reflection prompt: "A theology I once dismissed as wrong, which I can now see was simply using a different model from mine, is..."

LECTURE 25: What are the six models, and which one is mine?

The opening problem. Now set the whole workshop on the table at once. Stephen Bevans, watching how theology is actually done across the world, sorted the many ways of working into six models, and in this lecture the students meet all six in a single view, so that for the rest of the unit, and for the rest of their lives, they have a chart of the workshop in their heads. Pose the question that makes it personal: as you hear these six, ask which one your own heart already leans toward, and which one you most need to learn, because a theologian who knows only the model he was born liking is the workman with only a hammer from Lecture 24. The six are the translation model, the anthropological model, the praxis model, the synthetic model, the transcendental model, and the countercultural model. They differ in one chief thing, where they begin, and from that starting point flow their strengths and their dangers.

The teaching content. The translation model. This model begins with the Gospel as a message to be carried faithfully into every culture, like a content to be poured into new containers. It holds that the heart of the Gospel does not change, and that the work of theology is to find, in each culture, the right words and forms to carry that unchanging heart to a new people. Its strength is fidelity: it guards the identity of the faith and fears, rightly, that culture might dissolve the Gospel into itself. Its danger is that it can treat culture as a mere container and underestimate how deeply the Gospel itself, even in Scripture, already comes clothed in a culture; it can imagine a pure message with no clothing at all. Picture the same fresh milk poured into many vessels: the milk is one, but the pot of each house is its own, and the work is to pour the one milk truly into the pot of each people.

The anthropological model. This model begins not from the message brought in but from the culture and the human person already there, holding that God has been present and at work in every people long before the preacher arrived, so that the first task is to listen, to honour, and to find God already speaking in the culture. Its strength is that it takes the culture seriously and refuses to despise it, and it remembers that grace ran ahead of the missionary. Its danger is that it can grow romantic about a culture, overlooking the sin and the injustice woven into every human society, and forgetting that cultures, like persons, need not only affirming but converting. Picture a guest who arrives at a house expecting to find it cold and empty, and finds instead that the host has already swept the room and laid a place at the table; God, the true host, was there first.

The praxis model. This model begins from action, from the struggle for justice and the lived discipleship of the poor, holding that we come to know God truly not by thinking alone but by acting rightly and reflecting on the action, so that knowledge is born in the doing. Its strength is that it takes the suffering of the world and the demand of the Kingdom with deadly seriousness, and refuses a theology that changes nothing. Its danger is that, cut loose from the Word and the Tradition, it can shrink into mere politics or ideology. You learn

to ride a bicycle not from a book but in the riding, and this model says you come to know the God of justice in the doing of justice; the students will meet it at full strength in Lecture 26.

The synthetic model. This model refuses to begin from only one side, and seeks instead to hold together, in patient dialogue, the Gospel, the Tradition, the culture, and the demand for justice, borrowing wisely from all the others. Its strength is balance and conversation, the holding of many truths at once. Its danger is that, in trying to please every side, it can grow vague, a theology by committee that has lost its edge. Picture the making of bronze: copper alone is too soft and tin alone is too brittle, but melt and blend them and you have a metal stronger than either; the synthetic model is the blending that aims at a strength no single source has alone.

The transcendental model. This model begins not with a message or a culture or an action outside the theologian, but with the theologian himself as a knowing, believing, converted subject, holding that authentic theology flows from a mind and heart rightly disposed, attentive, intelligent, reasonable, responsible, and in love with God. It cares less about producing a fixed body of content than about the genuineness of the one who thinks. Its strength is that it goes to the root, the conversion of the knower, and takes the precepts of Lonergan to heart. Its danger is that it can grow abstract and turned inward, hard to grasp and hard to share. Picture a mirror: it shows the sun truly only if it is clean and rightly angled, and so this model polishes and angles the self first, trusting that right theology follows from a mind made true.

The countercultural model. This model takes culture with great seriousness, but precisely in order to name and resist what in a culture stands against the Gospel, holding that the Church is sometimes called to be a contrast-society, a people who live by a different story than the world around them. Its strength is that it is prophetic and names the idols, the greed, the violence, the contempt for the weak, that other models can be too gentle to confront. Its danger is that, overdone, it can turn the Church into a fortress that despises the world it was sent to save. Picture, at a great festival, the whole crowd streaming one way toward the fairground, and one man walking steadily against the crowd because a higher loyalty, an injured friend, pulls him the other way; the countercultural model is the Gospel walking against the crowd when the crowd is streaming toward an idol.

Which one is mine, and the payoff. Close by making it personal and reasonable at once. None of the six is simply right or simply wrong; each sees truly and partially, each has its gift and its temptation, and each fits some contexts and questions better than others. The reasonable theologian learns to recognise all six, knows which one his own temperament favours, deliberately learns the ones he finds hard, and chooses, for each piece of work, the model the matter calls for, often weaving two or three together. For the seminarian of Bengal this is not a chart to memorise for an examination, for there is none in this course; it is a set of tools he will carry into every parish, so that he can meet the migrant with one model, the seeker with another, and the silenced with a third, and serve each truly.

Illustration. The fresh images for this lecture are the six woven into the teaching above, one for each model, and you should draw them on the board as you go: the one milk poured into many vessels for the translation model; the guest who finds the room already swept and the

place already laid for the anthropological model; the rider who learns only in the riding for the praxis model; the blending of copper and tin into strong bronze for the synthetic model; the clean and rightly angled mirror for the transcendental model; and the one man walking against the festival crowd for the countercultural model. Keep all six on the board together at the end, six small pictures in a row, so that the students carry away a single chart of the workshop.

References. Stephen B. Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology*, revised edition (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2002), for the six models, their starting points, strengths, and dangers. Avery Dulles, *Models of Revelation*, for the method of working with models. For the praxis model, Gustavo Gutiérrez (cross-reference Lecture 15 and Lecture 26); for the countercultural model, Lesslie Newbigin and Stanley Hauerwas; for the anthropological model, Vincent Donovan, *Christianity Rediscovered*; for the transcendental model, the roots in Bernard Lonergan and Karl Rahner (cross-reference Lecture 8).

Cross-references. The six models are the working-out of the idea of a model from Lecture 24, and they will be put to work in Lecture 26, the praxis model in liberation and Dalit theology, Lecture 27, the anthropological and synthetic models in Indian theology, Lecture 28, the praxis and countercultural models in feminist theology, and Lecture 29, where Orthodox theology shows the transcendental and contemplative way at its deepest. The transcendental model rests on the precepts of Lonergan that have ordered this whole course. The countercultural model returns in Unit VI, where the Gospel must name the idols of the present age. The one and the many of Lecture 11 underlies the whole.

For the professor. Do not lecture the six models as six dry definitions; give each one its single fresh picture on the board as you reach it, and let the students feel the differences in their bodies. Then make it personal: ask them, by a show of hands or in their notebooks, which model their own heart already leans toward, and tell them that their growth will come from learning the models they find hardest. Stress the two dangers as much as the strengths, for a model loved uncritically becomes the hammer that sees only nails. Reading: Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology*, the central chapters. Reflection prompt: "The model my own heart leans toward is..., and the model I most need to learn is..., because..."

LECTURE 26: What does the world look like from below?

The opening problem. Begin with a hard fact the students half-know already. For most of its history, the theology that filled the libraries was written by men who were comfortable, educated, and free, men who never went hungry, never feared the police, never carried bricks for a living, never sat outside a village well waiting for the high-caste women to finish. What happens to theology when it is done, instead, from below, by and with the poor, the oppressed, the broken? Does the view from the floor of society see something the view from the study has missed? This is the question of liberation theology and, in our own land, of Dalit theology, and it is among the most important questions in this whole course for a priest who will serve in Bengal. Pose it plainly: the Gospel says God hears the cry of the poor, but does the poor person know something about God that the scholar does not? The

answer of these theologies is yes, and the reason is not sentiment but the praxis model of Lecture 25 taken with full seriousness.

The teaching content. Liberation theology and the praxis model. Liberation theology, born in Latin America with Gustavo Gutiérrez and others, is the praxis model at its sharpest. Recall the definition the students met in Lecture 15: theology as critical reflection on praxis in the light of the Word of God, where the praxis is the living-out of faith in solidarity with the poor and the struggle for their liberation. The method turns the old order around. It does not begin in the study with abstract questions and then look for an application; it begins in the lived commitment to the poor, in action for justice, and reflects on that action in the light of Scripture, and the reflection then returns to action made wiser. This is the pastoral cycle of Lecture 23, see, judge, act, with the poor not as the object seen but as the companions who see alongside you, and it carries a claim the students must weigh carefully: that there is an option for the poor, a special nearness of God to the broken, already written into Scripture from the cry at the burning bush to the Magnificat to the judgement of the nations, so that to stand with the poor is not a political choice added to the Gospel but a demand that rises from within it.

The view from below. Press the deeper claim, that social location shapes sight. The one who suffers an injustice knows it differently, and often more truly, than the one who only observes it, the way the one who carries a load knows its weight as the one who merely orders it never can. The poor see the cracks in a society that look, from above, like the natural order of things; they know from the inside what hunger, contempt, and powerlessness actually are. So liberation theology insists that the experience of the poor is a true source for theology, the fourth pillar of Lecture 23 at its costliest, and that a theology done only from above, however learned, will be blind to truths that are plain from below. This is not to romanticise poverty, which is an evil to be ended and never blessed in itself; it is to say that God, who chose to be born poor and to die condemned, is known in a particular way from the underside of history.

Dalit theology, the Indian sharpening. Now bring it home, for Bengal does not chiefly speak Spanish but lives the reality of caste. Dalit theology, with Arvind P. Nirmal and others, is the Indian voice of theology from below, and it makes a claim the students must hear without flinching. The very word Dalit means broken, crushed, ground down, and Dalit theology begins from the lived experience of the Dalit people, centuries of untouchability, humiliation, and exclusion, much of it suffered even within the Church. Nirmal taught that theology must be done from this pathos, this suffering, and he found at the heart of Scripture a God who is himself, so to speak, on the side of the broken: the suffering Servant of Isaiah, despised and rejected; the Christ who was crucified outside the gate, in the place of the outcast; a God who knows brokenness from within. And Nirmal pressed a hard and necessary criticism that the students must face honestly: that much classical Indian Christian theology, for all its beauty, had borrowed its categories from the high Sanskrit and Brahminic tradition, the very tradition that had kept the Dalit crushed, and so had spoken in the voice of the oppressor and left the Dalit unheard. Here two models, and two of the lectures of this unit, stand in real tension, and you must not hide it: the high inculturation theology of Lecture 27 and the Dalit theology of this lecture criticise

one another, and a reasonable theologian holds both, refusing to let inculturation become Brahminisation, and refusing to let the protest against caste throw away the genuine gift of inculturation.

The dangers, and the payoff. Be reasonable about the dangers, for the students will meet them. A liberation or Dalit theology that loses its mooring in the Word and the Tradition can collapse into mere politics or mere grievance, and a praxis that forgets prayer dries up. The marks of Lecture 10 still apply, and the test of fidelity still holds. But the gift is immense, and for Bengal it is not optional. The students will be ordained to serve, in large numbers, the poor, the Adivasi, the Dalit, the migrant, the woman doubly burdened; and a theology that cannot do its work from below, that can only descend with answers prepared above, will fail those people. The priest who has learned to do theology from the underside will preach a Gospel that is good news to the poor, as the Lord said it must be, and not merely good advice from the comfortable.

Illustration. The first image is the midwife, the village *dai*. No one learns to bring a child safely into the world from a book alone; the midwife knows birth in her hands, in the long night of labour with the mother, in the doing of it again and again. Liberation and Dalit theology are knowledge of that kind, knowledge born in the hands of those who labour alongside the poor through the long night, and not delivered, clean and finished, from a distant study. The midwife who had only read about birth, and never knelt by a labouring woman, would be of little use when the hour came; and a theology of the poor that has never accompanied them is of as little use. You come to know the God of the poor by labouring with the poor, which is the praxis model in flesh and blood.

The second image is the head-load carrier and the contractor. On any building site in Bengal you may see two people dealing with the same load of bricks. The contractor stands in the shade and orders so many thousand bricks; the woman carries them, on a pad on her head, up the bamboo scaffolding, trip after trip, all day. Both know the bricks, but only the woman knows their true weight, in her neck, her spine, her knees by evening. Ask the contractor the weight of the load and he will read you a figure from a paper; ask the woman and she will tell you with her whole tired body. The truth of an unjust society is known like the weight of that load, from under it, by the one who carries it; and theology from below is the discipline of listening to the carrier and not only to the one who orders the bricks. A Church that does its thinking only in the shade, from the figures on the paper, has never felt the weight its people carry.

References. Arvind P. Nirmal, "Towards a Christian Dalit Theology," and the wider Dalit theology he founded, for theology done from the pathos of the broken and for the criticism of Sanskrit inculturation. Gustavo Gutiérrez, *A Theology of Liberation* (1971), for theology as critical reflection on praxis and the option for the poor (cross-reference Lecture 15). Stephen B. Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology*, on the praxis model. For the Scriptural ground: Exodus 3:7, the Servant Song of Isaiah 52:13 to 53:12, Luke 1:46 to 55, Luke 4:18, Matthew 25:31 to 46, and Hebrews 13:12, the suffering outside the gate, all in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition.

Cross-references. The praxis model comes from Lecture 25, the cry of the poor and the option for the poor from Lecture 15, and the pastoral cycle and the hermeneutic circle from Lecture 23. The view from below was promised in the architecture of the course and is here at full strength. The real tension between Dalit theology and the high inculturation of Lecture 27 must be held, not hidden, and it returns in the responsible theologian of Lecture 34 and in dialogue and pluralism in Lecture 33. The suffering Servant and the Christ crucified outside the gate reach back to the person of Christ in Lecture 18. The marks and the test of fidelity from Lecture 10 keep this theology honest.

For the professor. This lecture will touch your students personally, for many of them, or their people, know caste and poverty from the inside, and you must let it be felt and not merely studied. Insist on both the gift and the danger: the gift, that the Gospel is good news to the poor and is known truly from below; the danger, that a praxis cut off from the Word and from prayer withers into politics or grievance. Do not hide the hard quarrel between Dalit theology and Sanskritic inculturation; lay it open and show the students that holding both, refusing both Brahminisation and bare protest, is exactly what being reasonable demands. Reading: Nirmal on Christian Dalit theology; Gutiérrez, the opening of *A Theology of Liberation*. Reflection prompt: "A truth about God that I have learned, or could learn, from a poor or a Dalit person, which my studies did not teach me, is..."

LECTURE 27: Can the Gospel feel at home in India?

The opening problem. For a long time, and in many places still, Christianity in India has been made to look like a foreign religion, the religion of the colonisers, dressed in foreign clothes, praying in foreign forms, thinking in foreign words, so that to become a Christian seemed to mean leaving India behind. Pose the question that this raises and that Indian theology exists to answer: can the Gospel feel at home in India, take Indian flesh, pray with folded hands, sit on the floor, think with the mind of this ancient land, without ceasing to be the Gospel? This is the work of inculturation, and it draws chiefly on the anthropological and synthetic models of Lecture 25. The students must hold this lecture and the last one together, for the theology of the poor and the theology of inculturation both belong to India and yet pull against each other, and a reasonable theologian serves both.

The teaching content. Inculturation and the anthropological model. Begin from the conviction of the anthropological model, that God has been at work in India for all its long history, long before the missionaries came, in the deep longing of its people for the Absolute, in their genius for prayer and renunciation, in their reverence for the guru, the ashram, and the sacred word. Inculturation is the Gospel taking flesh in a particular culture, as the Word took flesh in a particular Jewish village, so that the faith is no longer a foreign guest but a member of the household. This is not a betrayal of the Gospel but the imitation of the Incarnation itself, and the Second Vatican Council and the Asian bishops have called the Indian Church to it. The work is to let Christ be born again in Indian forms, in Indian prayer, in Indian art, in Indian thought, so that an Indian need not stop being Indian in order to belong wholly to Christ.

Thinking with the darshanas. Show the students that this is exactly what the great ages of the Church have always done, so that inculturation is not a novelty but a tradition. The Fathers thought the Gospel with the help of Greek philosophy, Lecture 18; Aquinas thought it with Aristotle, Lecture 19; and India is now called to think it with the *darshanas*, the classical schools of Indian philosophy, above all with the *advaita*, the non-dual Vedanta, as its conversation partner. A line of pioneers walked this road: Brahmabandhab Upadhyay, who sought to express the Trinity with the categories of *Saccidananda*, being, consciousness, and bliss; the monks Abhishiktananda and Bede Griffiths, who lived the Christian faith in the form of the Indian sannyasi; and Michael Amaladoss and others who have carried the work forward. Just as the word *homousios* was a Greek word pressed into the service of Christ, so Indian theology asks which words and forms of this land can carry the mystery of Christ truly. The synthetic model of Lecture 25 is at work here, holding Gospel, Tradition, and the Indian inheritance in patient dialogue, aiming at a faith that is fully Christian and fully Indian at once.

The triple dialogue. Give the students the shape that the Asian bishops and Amaladoss have given to the whole task, the triple dialogue, for it gathers this unit together. The Church in Asia is called to a threefold conversation: a dialogue with the many cultures of the land, which is inculturation, the matter of this lecture; a dialogue with the many religions of the land, the Hindu, the Muslim, the Buddhist, the Sikh, the tribal traditions, which is interreligious dialogue, the matter of Lecture 33; and a dialogue with the poor, the vast suffering majority, which is liberation, the matter of Lecture 26. These three are not three separate jobs to be done one after another but three strands of one rope, and Indian theology is strong only when all three are held together. Cut the strand of the poor, and inculturation becomes a pretty game for the comfortable; cut the strand of the cultures, and the Gospel stays foreign; cut the strand of the religions, and the Church lives as a stranger among her neighbours.

The honest tension, and the dangers. Be reasonable, and do not pretend the road is smooth. The students met in Lecture 26 the sharp criticism of the Dalit theologians, that high inculturation has too often borrowed from the Sanskritic and Brahminic tradition, the tradition of the upper castes, and so has spoken past the Dalit and the Adivasi, who are the majority of the Indian Church. This is a serious charge and a true warning, and the reasonable answer is not to abandon inculturation but to widen it, to inculturate the Gospel not only into the high Sanskritic forms but into the cultures of the Adivasi and the Dalit, the Santali song, the tribal dance, the folk story, which are also India and are nearer to most of the people in the pews of Bengal. The other danger is syncretism, the blurring of the Gospel into the surrounding religion until Christ becomes merely one teacher among many; against this stand the marks and the banks of Lecture 10, for inculturation must keep the identity of the faith even as it changes its dress.

The payoff. Tell the students what this means for them directly. They will serve a Church that worships in Bengali and in Santali, that uses Indian melodies and Indian gestures, that lives among Hindu and Muslim neighbours, and that is overwhelmingly poor and largely Adivasi and Dalit. To do theology in the Indian key, with all three strands of the rope held together, is simply to serve that real Church faithfully, so that the people of Bengal may

meet a Christ who speaks their tongue, sits on their floor, and stands with them in their poverty, and is, for all that, truly the one Lord confessed at Nicaea and Chalcedon.

Illustration. The first image is the Gospel learning to sit on the floor and eat with the hand. Picture a guest from far away who comes to live in a Bengal village. If he insists on his own high chair while everyone else sits on the floor, demands a fork and a loaf while the family eats rice with the hand, and offers his stiff foreign greeting while they fold their hands in *namaste*, he may stay for years and never truly enter the home; he remains a foreigner under the roof. But if he learns to sit on the mat, to eat the rice with his fingers, to fold his hands in greeting, to speak the tongue of the house, then he is received, and the family forgets he was ever a stranger. Inculturation is the Gospel learning to sit on the floor of India, to pray with folded hands, to think with the mind of the land, so that it is no longer the religion of the foreigner but a member of the Indian household, born again in Indian flesh as once it was born in the flesh of a Jewish village.

The second image is the three-stranded rope. A rope made of a single strand is easily snapped, but a rope of three strands twisted together is strong, and Scripture itself says that a threefold cord is not quickly broken (Ecclesiastes 4:12). Indian theology is such a threefold cord: the strand of dialogue with the cultures, the strand of dialogue with the religions, and the strand of dialogue with the poor, twisted into one. Hold all three and the rope is strong enough to bear the weight of the Indian Church; cut any one, and the rope is weakened and may part under the load. The temptation is always to keep the one strand we like and let the others fray, the comfortable keeping inculturation and dropping the poor, the activist keeping the poor and despising the cultures; but the rope holds only when all three are twisted tight together.

References. Michael Amaladoss, *Theologizing in India Today*, and his wider writings on inculturation and the triple dialogue, for the shape of Indian theology. Stephen B. Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology*, on the anthropological and synthetic models. For the pioneers: Brahmabandhab Upadhyay on *Saccidananda* and the Trinity; Abhishiktananda, that is, Henri Le Saux, and Bede Griffiths on the Christian sannyasi and *advaita*. The Federation of Asian Bishops' Conferences, for the triple dialogue with cultures, religions, and the poor. Ecclesiastes 4:12, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition, for the threefold cord. For the criticism of Sanskrit inculturation, the Dalit theology of Lecture 26.

Cross-references. The anthropological and synthetic models come from Lecture 25, and the conversation with the *darshanas* continues the work of the Fathers with the Greeks in Lecture 18 and of Aquinas with Aristotle in Lecture 19, the baptising of a philosophy named in Lecture 11. The triple dialogue gathers the liberation of Lecture 26, the interreligious dialogue of Lecture 33, and the inculturation of this lecture into one rope. The honest tension with Dalit theology comes from Lecture 26 and returns in Lecture 34. The danger of syncretism is held in check by the marks and banks of Lecture 10. The Christ who is both fully Indian and fully the Lord of Nicaea reaches back to Lecture 18.

For the professor. Make this lecture a homecoming, for it tells your students that they need not choose between being Indian and being wholly Christian. Show them the pioneers as real and daring people, monks who lived in ashrams and thinkers who pressed Sanskrit

words into the service of Christ. But keep it reasonable and honest: widen inculturation past the Sanskritic to the Adivasi and Dalit cultures of your own people, hold the three strands of the rope together, and guard against the blurring of Christ into one teacher among many. End by tying this lecture to the last, so the students feel the tension between Dalit protest and high inculturation as a tension a faithful priest must carry, not resolve by amputation. Reading: Amaladoss, *Theologizing in India Today*. Reflection prompt: "One Indian form, of prayer, art, story, or thought, through which I would like to help my people meet Christ, is..."

LECTURE 28: What changes when a woman does theology?

The opening problem. Put a simple historical fact before the students, and let it land. For almost the whole history of the Church, theology was written by men: the Fathers, the schoolmen, the reformers, the manualists, nearly all men, thinking about God, naming God, and deciding what the experience of being human before God means, while half the Church, the women, sat largely silent in the writing of it, however deeply they lived the faith. Pose the question honestly and without heat: what is lost when only half the Church does the theology, and what changes when a woman takes up the work? This is feminist theology, and the students should meet it calmly and reasonably, neither dismissing it as a foreign fashion nor swallowing every claim made in its name. It draws on the praxis and countercultural models of Lecture 25, and at its best it does two things, it asks that the experience of women be heard as a true source, and it recovers the images of God, already in Scripture, that a male-only theology had passed over.

The teaching content. The claim, and the source. The first claim of feminist theology is the claim of the praxis model and of theology from below, met in Lecture 26, now applied to women: that the lived experience of women, who are the majority of the praying, serving Church and who carry particular burdens of suffering and exclusion, is a true source for theology, the fourth pillar of Lecture 23, and that a theology deaf to that experience is, by that much, poorer and less true. This is not to set women against men, but to say that the whole human experience, and not only its male half, must feed the Church reflection on God. Elizabeth Johnson, whose portrait the students read in Ormerod, takes up exactly this in her work on how the Church speaks of God, arguing that the way we name God shapes the way we value persons, so that a God spoken of only in images of male power can quietly teach a Church to undervalue women, and that to speak rightly of the mystery of God we must use the full range of images God has given.

Recovering what was always there. Show the students that the deepest work here is not invention but recovery, a *ressourcement* in the sense of Lecture 22, a return to riches already in the house. The Scriptures themselves speak of God in womanly images that the Church has too seldom preached. God asks whether a mother can forget the child of her womb, and says that even if she could, he will not forget his people (Isaiah 49:15). God promises to comfort his people as a mother comforts her child (Isaiah 66:13). The Lord Jesus likens himself to a hen gathering her chicks under her wings (Matthew 23:37), and

tells of a woman who sweeps the whole house to find one lost coin and calls in her neighbours to rejoice, as an image of God seeking the lost (Luke 15:8 to 10). And the Wisdom of God, *Sophia*, by whom all things were made, is sung in the Scriptures in the figure of a woman (Proverbs 8). These images were always in the Bible; feminist theology, at its best, walks around the pillar to see the faces of God that the Church had stopped looking at, and so makes the Church speech about God fuller and more biblical, not less.

The countercultural edge, and being reasonable. Add the countercultural element of Lecture 25, for feminist theology also stands, prophetically, against the contempt for women woven into many cultures, including aspects of our own, the dowry deaths, the unwanted girl child, the silencing of the widow, and it reads the Gospel as good news for women as Lecture 26 read it as good news for the poor. Now be reasonable, for the students must learn to weigh as well as to receive. Like every model, feminist theology has its gift and its danger. Its gift is the recovery of the female images of God, the hearing of half the Church, and the prophetic stand against real injustice. Its danger, when it slips its moorings, is the same as that of any praxis theology, that it can be captured by an ideology and made to contradict the Scripture and the Tradition it claims to read, failing the test of fidelity from Lecture 10; and the students will meet feminist theologians who have worked faithfully within the Church and others whose conclusions the Church has judged to have gone past the bounds, which is itself an instance of the bond between the theologian and the teaching office from Lecture 14, to be taken up fully in Lecture 34. The reasonable course is neither to reject the whole nor to swallow it whole, but to receive its genuine gift, the fuller naming of God and the hearing of women, while holding it, like every model, to coherence and fidelity.

The payoff. Tell the students what this means in a Bengal parish. The women in their pews will be the backbone of the parish, the catechists, the prayer leaders, the carers of the sick and the dying, the ones who keep the faith alive in the home; and a priest who has learned to hear the experience of women as a true source, and to preach the God who is like a mother who cannot forget her child, will serve them and the whole community better than one who has only ever heard the male half of the Church. He will also be better armed to stand, in the name of the Gospel, against the real contempt for women and girls that scars so many homes.

Illustration. The first image is the family council where only the sons are asked to speak. Picture a large joint family that meets, generation after generation, to take its important decisions, and at every meeting only the sons are invited to speak, while the daughters, who know the family and its wounds and its needs just as deeply, sit in silence at the back. The family is not evil; it simply never thought to ask. But its wisdom is halved, its decisions are poorer for the silence, and the daughters carry insight that never reaches the council. Feminist theology, at its best, is the daughters of the Church asking to be heard at the family council, not against the family but for the sake of its whole wisdom; and a Church that learns to ask the daughters too will find that it had been thinking with half its mind.

The second image is the carved temple pillar whose other faces are there all along. On a temple pillar the carver has often worked all four sides, but the pilgrims who always pass on

the same side, year after year, see only the one face and come to think that is the whole pillar. Walk around it, and there are three more faces, carved with as much care, there from the beginning. The Scriptures have carved the face of God not only as father and king but as a mother who cannot forget the child of her womb, as a woman searching the house for the lost coin, as the Wisdom by whom the world was made; and these faces were there from the beginning, only the Church too seldom walked around the pillar to see them. To recover them is not to carve something new onto God but to look at last at what the Word had carved all along.

References. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, the portrait of Elizabeth Johnson, pages 185 to 194, for feminist theology and the naming of God. Elizabeth A. Johnson, *She Who Is: The Mystery of God in Feminist Theological Discourse* (1992), for speaking rightly of the mystery of God and for the recovery of Wisdom. Stephen B. Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology*, on the praxis and countercultural models. For the womanly images of God: Isaiah 49:15, Isaiah 66:13, Matthew 23:37, Luke 15:8 to 10, and Proverbs 8, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition. For the bond of the theologian and the teaching office, *Donum Veritatis* (cross-reference Lecture 14 and Lecture 34).

Cross-references. The claim that the experience of women is a true source rests on the fourth pillar of Lecture 23 and on theology from below in Lecture 26. The recovery of the womanly images of God is a *ressourcement* in the sense of Lecture 22, a return to the sources of Lecture 12. The countercultural edge comes from the model named in Lecture 25 and returns in Unit VI. The reasonable weighing of gift and danger rests on the two tests of Lecture 24 and the marks of Lecture 10, and the case of feminist theologians and the teaching office is an instance of Lecture 14 and looks forward to Lecture 34. The fuller naming of the mystery of God reaches back to the Trinity of Lecture 3 and the apophatic theology of Lecture 29.

For the professor. Teach this lecture calmly and reasonably, for your students may arrive with strong feelings on both sides. Steer them away from two errors at once: the dismissal that will not even hear the genuine gift, and the uncritical embrace that swallows every claim without weighing it. Centre the lecture on the recovery of the womanly images of God already in Scripture, for this is solid ground, deeply biblical, and pastorally rich, and it lets the students see that feminist theology at its best makes the Church speech about God fuller and more faithful, not less. Then be honest about the danger, and tie the harder cases to the bond of theologian and teaching office. Reading: Ormerod, the portrait of Johnson, pages 185 to 194. Reflection prompt: "An image of God as a mother, or a truth about God I have learned from the women of my own family or parish, is..."

LECTURE 29: Can you do theology on your knees?

The opening problem. This whole unit has been about method, about tools, models, sources, and the disciplined craft of the theologian, and there is a danger in all of it that the students should now feel: that theology might shrink into a technique, a clever managing of texts and models, with the living God left somewhere outside the workshop. So end the unit

with the question that the Christian East has never let the Church forget. Can you do theology on your knees? Is theology finally a science to be mastered or a prayer to be prayed? The theology of the Orthodox Church, which the students meet in the portrait of John Meyendorff, answers without hesitation: the theologian is the one who prays, and prayer and theology are not two things but one. Evagrius of Pontus put it in a line the students should carry for life: the one who prays truly is a theologian, and the theologian is the one who prays truly. This lecture is the transcendental and contemplative way of Lecture 25 and Lecture 7 at its deepest, and it is the necessary correction to a unit full of methods.

The teaching content. Theology and prayer are one. The first thing the Christian East has to teach is that, in its tradition, theology was never cut off from prayer. The greatest Eastern theologians were monks and bishops who prayed before they wrote and whose writing was a form of prayer; theology was the overflow of a life turned toward God, the doxological and contemplative sense of theology the students met in Lecture 7. To know God is not first to master propositions about God but to be united to God in love, and so the proud, grasping intellect that would seize God as an object and file him among its conclusions has, by that very grasping, missed him. This is the great rebuke the East offers to a theology that has become only a technique: you cannot do this work rightly except on your knees.

The apophatic way. Give the students the heart of Eastern theology, the apophatic or negative way, and connect it to what they already learned from Marcel in Lecture 21. God is infinitely greater than every concept we can form of him, so that our truest speech about God must finally pass into silence and adoration; we know God more truly by what he is not than by what he is, and the height of theology is not a full notebook but a holy unknowing, a being overwhelmed by a light too great for the eye. This is not ignorance and not laziness; it is the most rigorous honesty about the difference between the Creator and the creature. The Eastern Fathers and writers, Gregory of Nyssa, Pseudo-Dionysius, Gregory Palamas, taught that we may truly know God in his energies, his acts and his light reaching out to us, while his very essence remains for ever beyond our grasp, so that the closer the saint comes, the more he knows how far God exceeds him. The goal of it all is *theosis*, deification, the teaching the students met from Athanasius in Lecture 18, that God became man so that man might become god by grace, sharing the very life of God.

Worship, the icon, and the payoff. Show the students that for the East this is not abstract, for it is carried in worship and in the icon. The liturgy is itself theology, sung and enacted; the icon is theology written in line and colour, and the one who writes an icon fasts and prays as he works, because the image is a prayer made visible. And here is the gift this lecture brings to a unit full of methods, and the reason it closes Unit V. All the models and tools the students have learned are good and necessary, but they are servants, and their master is the living God who is known in prayer. A theologian who masters every model and never prays has become a skilled technician of a craft whose object he has not met. The seminarian of Bengal, who will be busy all his life with homilies, classes, accounts, and meetings, needs this lecture most of all, for it tells him that his theology will be true and living only if it is done, finally, on his knees, and that the day he stops praying is the day his theology, however clever, begins to die.

Illustration. The first image is the sun that cannot be stared at. You cannot look straight at the midday sun; stare at it and you are dazzled, blinded, and see nothing at all, and the proud eye that tries to seize the sun is punished with darkness. Yet it is by the light of that same sun, which you cannot look at, that you see everything else, the road, the faces, the fields. So it is with God in the apophatic way. The intellect that tries to stare God down, to seize him and hold him as one more object of knowledge, is blinded and grasps nothing; and yet it is in the light of this God, whom no mind can look at directly, that everything else is truly seen. Theology on its knees is the lowering of the proud eye before a light too great for it, and the discovery that in that very lowering one begins to see.

The second image is the iconographer who prays as he writes the icon. In the Christian East the making of an icon is not called painting but writing, and the one who writes it prepares by fasting and prayer, and prays through every hour of the work, because the icon is not a picture about prayer but an act of prayer that has become visible in wood and colour and gold. The icon and the prayer are not two separate things, the prayer first and the picture after; they are one act. So it is with theology in this tradition: the thinking and the praying are not two separate works, the prayer first and the theology after, but one act, faith adoring God with the whole mind. The day the iconographer stops praying, his hand may still move but the icon dies under it; and the day the theologian stops praying, his pen may still move but the theology dies under it.

References. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, the portrait of John Meyendorff, pages 205 to 214, for the trends and themes of Eastern theology. Evagrius of Pontus, *Chapters on Prayer* (also called *On Prayer*), for the one who prays truly being a theologian. John Meyendorff, *Byzantine Theology: Historical Trends and Doctrinal Themes*, for Palamas, the essence and energies, and *theosis*. Vladimir Lossky, *The Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church*, for the apophatic way. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation*, for deification (cross-reference Lecture 18). The Second Council of Nicaea (787), for the place of the icon.

Cross-references. The contemplative and doxological sense of theology comes from Lecture 7, the mystery that the whole person enters from Marcel in Lecture 21, and the transcendental model, the converted and praying subject, from Lecture 25. Deification reaches back to Athanasius and the Fathers in Lecture 18, and the apophatic naming of God meets the fuller naming of God in Lecture 28 and the mystery of the Trinity in Lecture 3. This lecture is the necessary correction to a unit full of methods, and it carries the precept be reasonable to its proper humility, for the most reasonable thing a theologian can know is that God exceeds his reason. It prepares the responsible theologian of Lecture 34, who must be a person of prayer, and the Manifesto of Lecture 35.

For the professor. Place this lecture deliberately at the close of the unit, and tell the students why it stands there: after six lectures of tools and models, they need to be reminded that the tools are servants and the living God is the master, and that he is met on the knees and not only at the desk. Let the lecture itself be a little prayerful, perhaps reading the line of Evagrius slowly and sitting with it in silence for a moment. Make it personal and urgent for men who will be busy all their lives: the day you stop praying, your

theology begins to die. Reading: Ormerod, the portrait of Meyendorff, pages 205 to 214; Evagrius, *On Prayer*. Reflection prompt: "Whether my study of theology this year has drawn me closer to God in prayer, or quietly become a technique apart from prayer, is..."

CLOSING THE UNIT, AND THE BRIDGE TO UNIT VI

By the end of Unit V the students should be able to say, with confidence, how theology is actually done. They have learned the general craft, the four pillars on which all theology stands, the pastoral cycle of seeing, judging, and acting, and the spiral by which the theologian reads the Word and the world each in the light of the other. They have learned why theology needs many models and not one, and they hold the six models of Bevans as tools in a bag: translation, anthropological, praxis, synthetic, transcendental, and countercultural. And they have watched those models at work in the living theologies they will actually serve: the praxis model in liberation and Dalit theology, the view from below; the anthropological and synthetic models in Indian inculturation, with its threefold cord of cultures, religions, and the poor; the praxis and countercultural models in theology done in the voice of a woman; and, closing the unit on its knees, the contemplative and apophatic theology of the Christian East. Above all they have practised the third precept of Lonergan, be reasonable: to weigh the models, to give reasons, to choose the tool the matter calls for, and to test every theology by coherence and by fidelity, while learning from the East that the most reasonable knowledge of all is that God exceeds our reason and is met in prayer.

One question now remains, and it is the one toward which the whole course has been moving. Given all that they have received, the sources, the history, and the methods, how shall they themselves do theology today, responsibly, in the real India of this hour? That is the work of the final unit, Unit VI, doing theology today, Lectures 30 to 35, where the fourth and last precept, be responsible, begins to govern. There the students will face the questions of their own age, artificial intelligence and the machine that arranges words about God, the synodal Church that listens, the cry of the wounded earth bound to the cry of the poor, and the many faiths among whom they live; and there they will be asked, at the last, what kind of theologian each of them will choose to become, and will write their own Theology Manifesto. The next installment of these notes will cover Unit VI, in the same form, and will carry the course to its destination.

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